

Meetup: Mentorship in HCI × Health Research

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Abstract

This meetup is a mentorship and community-building space for researchers working in HCI × Health, including undergraduate and graduate students, postdoctoral fellows, and early-career faculty. Through two activities, participants will have the opportunity to discuss challenges they currently face when establishing their careers. In a 60-min structured mentorship discussion activity, mentors will share experiences in three rotations around five possible selected topics. Then during a 30-minute social networking session, participants will engage in a *This or That* game. This meetup will strengthen relationships and foster new connections that can have profound effects on the careers of researchers-in-training.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

Interactive Health, Health, Mentorship

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1 Context and Goals

Health has become one of the most active areas of HCI research. At CHI, the Health subcommittee is now among the largest, and in 2026 the ACM will launch the *Interactive Health* conference as a dedicated venue. This growth demonstrates a broad recognition that HCI can make significant contributions to health and well-being, from the design of patient-facing technologies to the support of clinical practices and policy development. Yet, much of this work is conducted across disciplinary boundaries and researchers often hold expertise in both HCI and a specialized area of health, such as clinical medicine, public health, or rehabilitation. Such interdisciplinary work enables innovation but also raises distinctive challenges, including navigating methodological differences and aligning expectations across fields [4]. So, while this dual positioning creates opportunities for impactful scholarship, it also makes it more difficult to find mentors and peers who share comparable experience. Building stronger connections across these boundaries is therefore a pressing need. Mentorship is especially important in this context. Mentors provide explicit knowledge of research practice—methods, theories, tools—and they also guide the implicit norms of authorship, communication, and interpretation [8]. In health-focused HCI, researchers must uniquely balance HCI's emphasis on short-term proofs-of-concept with Health's emphasis on long-term efficacy [7]. They must also navigate structural barriers, including the lack of formal training, limited shared vocabularies across disciplines, and insufficient institutional and funding incentives to support sustained collaboration [1, 9]. Further, researchers often wrestle with tensions between probe- and product-oriented approaches, while also facing challenges to their own well-being as they strive to produce compelling contributions [6]. These disciplinary and structural tensions underline the importance of strong mentorship for researchers entering the space.

This meetup is designed to provide mentorship for undergraduate and graduate students, postdoctoral fellows, and early-career faculty who wish to establish a career at the intersection of HCI

and Health. Through participant-led facilitated discussions, we will engage with specific challenges, such as initiating fieldwork in hospitals or adapting to clinical workflows [3], while also sharing strategies for sustaining careers in this interdisciplinary space. In doing so, the event builds on initiatives such as the WISH symposia [5] and workshops envisioning the Interactive Health conference [2], extending these efforts with a dedicated focus on mentorship and community-building at CHI 2026.

2 Structure of Activities

The meetup will be divided into two parts, a structured mentorship discussion and a fun social networking session. The **structured mentorship discussion** will last 60 minutes, the goal is for the mentors to share experiences around five topics in a round-robin rotation format. The organizers will create groups of 2–10 mentors (depending on the number of tables) around a shared research interest (e.g., mental health and well-being, interactive hospital systems, care work, etc.) and assign them a table that meet-up participants can then join freely. Discussions will unfold over three 18-minute segments in which the mentors share experiences and answer questions centered around their table's topic:

- (1) **Career Building.** HCI researchers working in health work in a variety of organizations, institutions, and departments (e.g., computing, design, medical). Discussions in this topic will include: choosing career paths, navigating expectations of different environments, building bridges with different academic communities, reaching work–life balance, and sustaining mental health while building a career.
- (2) **Conducting fieldwork in Health.** Conducting HCI research requires working directly with end-users and other stakeholders, but these activities can be particularly challenging in health. Participants in this conversation will share challenges and possible approaches for addressing them. Topics of discussion will include: practical challenges, ethical issues, working with at-risk populations, data protection, and protecting researchers when working on difficult topics.
- (3) **Building and maintaining collaborations.** Conducting HCI research in healthcare is often in collaboration with clinicians, healthcare researchers, community workers, and patient researchers. This discussion topic will focus on finding partners, aligning research visions, sustaining collaborations, and retribution/reciprocity.
- (4) **Creating appropriate technology.** Technologies that comes out of labs can strongly impact users' health and lives, thus it is important to be especially reflective about what kind of technology we are involved in creating. Topics of discussion include: involving diverse audiences, ethical reflection in design, and monitoring use to ensure appropriate impact.
- (5) **Publishing multidisciplinary work.** Navigating academic publishing is complicated for all researchers, especially those working in highly multidisciplinary areas, such as HCI researchers working in health contexts. This topic will focus on selecting where to publish, communicating HCI work to healthcare professionals, dealing with different writing styles from collaborators, or engaging with non-HCI reviewers.

The **social networking session** will last 30 minutes, and the goal is to have a fun, reduce clustering and increase circulation in the room (and our bodies). We will conduct a This or That game, where we ask subjective questions crossing HCI and Health, e.g., “Would you rather interview a taciturn clinician or a rambler patient?”, and participants will pick a position by moving to that half of the room. Organizers will finish the game when participants are energized and organically discussing with each other, also handing out small participation prizes (candy and IH '26 stickers).

3 Organizers

Ignacio Avellino is a tenured research fellow at CNRS and Sorbonne Université, Paris, France. His research lies at the intersection of interaction, collaboration and learning, applied to surgical work, with an emphasis on supporting clinicians in imparting knowledge through surgical telementoring and pedagogical videos.

James R. Wallace is a Professor in the School of Public Health Sciences at the University of Waterloo, cross appointed to the Chertoff School of Computer Science. His research focuses on games for health behaviour change, and understanding how theory and tools from HCI can intersect with those from Public Health.

Francisco Nunes is a Senior Researcher at Fraunhofer Portugal AICOS. His research is concerned with the understanding, design, and evaluation of healthcare technologies, with a special interest in self-care technologies.

Jason Wiese is an Associate Professor in the Kahlert School of Computing at the University of Utah, USA. His research focuses on technology use in a variety of applied health contexts, including clinical settings and for home use by consumers, personal informatics systems, and accessibility for people with complex conditions.

Helena M. Mentis is a Professor and Head of the Department of Information Science at Drexel University, USA. She investigates situated communication and collaboration practices in healthcare, and, in turn, develops and deploys new mechanisms for collaboratively sensing, presenting, and interacting with information.

Sean Munson is a Professor of Human Centered Design & Engineering at the University of Washington. He examines, designs, and evaluates personal informatics technologies, with a focus on using personal data to support understanding and managing health concerns and goals.

Aneesha Singh is a Professor in HCI and Digital Health at the University College London Interaction Centre. She is interested in the design, adoption and use of personal health and wellbeing technologies in everyday contexts, focusing on interactive systems particularly for sensitive conditions and under-served communities.

Christina Chung is an Associate Professor in Computational Media at the University of California, Santa Cruz. She studies how ubiquitous computing and personal informatics technology can be designed to support the changing and social nature of everyday behavior and contexts.

Pin Sym Foong is Head of Design at the Telehealth Core at the National University Health System in Singapore. She currently studies medical decision-making among laypersons, particularly in sensitive contexts such as care at the end-of-life.

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